

Operational AI adoption pathways

Integration, governance, automated decisions and in-house development are distinct operational choices.

Among AI-using SMEs, integration and policy/guidance point estimates are higher than automated decision-making. In-house AI development/training remains uncommon across all SMEs.

Evidence scope

Tables 43, 48 and 50 describe AI-using businesses. Table 47 describes all businesses. The indicators are shown in separate denominator panels and are not combined into a maturity score.

UKBDS Official source DSIT 2026	95% Uncertainty Intervals retained	SMEs Primary scope Large shown separately
--	---	--

Executive summary

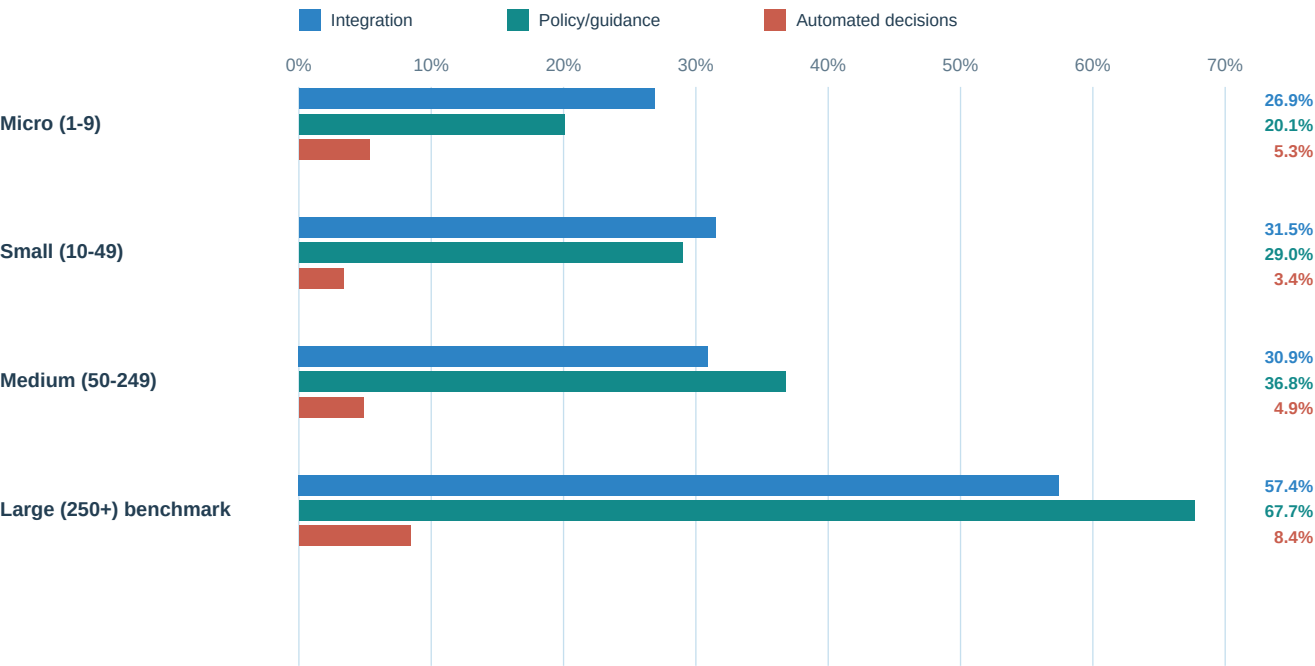
26.9%-31.5 % Integration Among AI-using SMEs	20.1%-36.8 % Policy/guidance Among AI-using SMEs	3.4%-5.3% Automated decisions Among AI-using SMEs	3.3%-6.5% In-house build/train Across all SMEs
--	--	--	---

Operational adoption is not one linear ladder. Businesses may integrate, govern, automate, develop or train AI in different combinations. The source supports separate measures, not a single readiness score.

Integration is the most common listed operational measure Among AI-using micro and small businesses, its point estimate is above policy/guidance and automated decisions.	Governance increases with size The policy/guidance point estimate rises across micro, small and medium AI users.
Automated decisions remain limited Point estimates are below 6% for each SME group among AI users.	In-house build/training is uncommon Across all businesses, the SME point estimates range from 3.3% to 6.5%.

Operationalisation is better understood as a set of choices and controls than as a single maturity score.

Conditional pathways among businesses already using AI

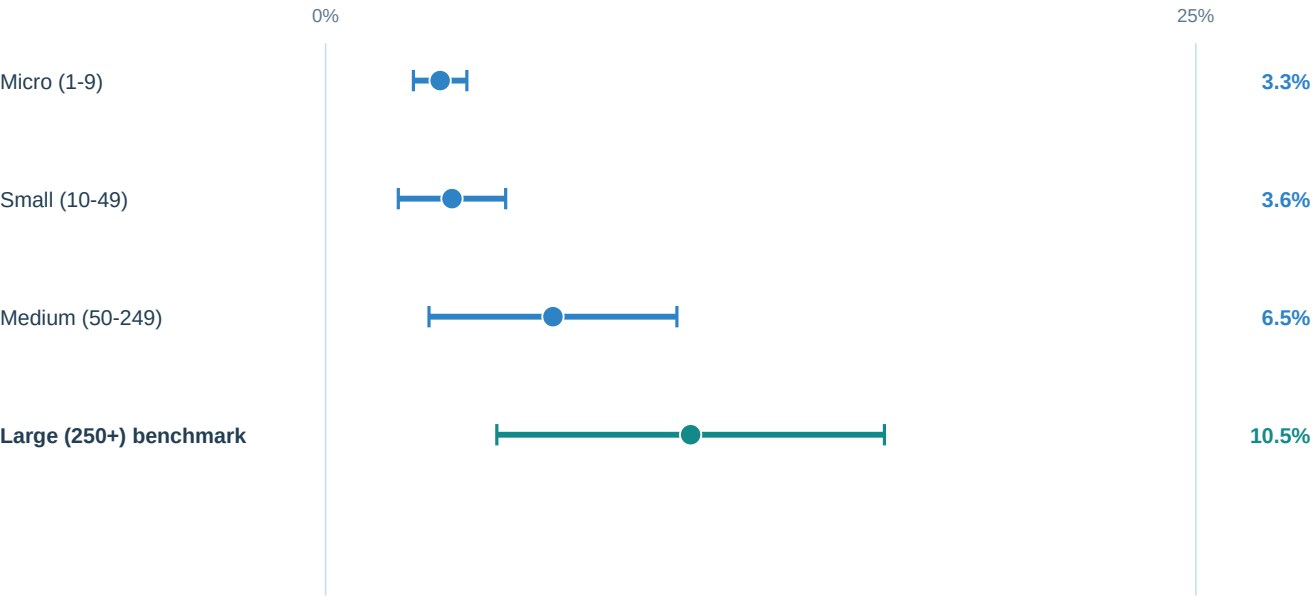


Business size	Integration	Policy/guidance	Automated decisions
Micro (1-9)	26.9%	20.1%	5.3%
Small (10-49)	31.5%	29.0%	3.4%
Medium (50-249)	30.9%	36.8%	4.9%
Large (250+) benchmark	57.4%	67.7%	8.4%

All three measures on this page describe businesses already using AI. They are distinct indicators and are not required stages.

In-house AI development or training across all businesses

Denominator: all UK businesses within each published size group.



Business size	Estimate	95% interval	Rounded base
Micro (1-9)	3.3%	2.5-4.1%	2,500
Small (10-49)	3.6%	2.1-5.2%	680
Medium (50-249)	6.5%	3.0-10.1%	220
Large (250+) benchmark	10.5%	4.9-16.1%	130

This indicator is uncommon across SMEs. It does not reveal whether businesses buy external tools, configure existing products or use third-party support.

Decision use: four separate operating questions

Integrate Which systems, data flows and process owners are involved, and how are exceptions handled?	Govern What proportionate rules, responsibilities and human-review requirements apply?
Automate Which decisions are suitable for automation, and where must accountability stay explicitly human?	Build or train Is in-house development genuinely necessary, or can the problem be solved through existing tools and process redesign?

Cross-pathway insight

- For AI-using SMEs, integration and governance are more common in the point estimates than automated decision-making.
- In-house development or training is a separate all-business measure and remains uncommon among SMEs.
- The evidence does not support a fixed sequence in which every business must use, integrate, automate and build.
- A practical adoption plan should select only the pathways justified by the task, risk, data and available capability.

Useful insight: operational AI support should distinguish workflow integration, governance, automation and technical build capability rather than packaging them as one service.

Method, interpretation and source trail

These reports retain the survey definitions rather than treating every percentage as directly comparable.

Source and fieldwork

Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, UK Business Data Survey 2026. Fieldwork ran from 10 October 2025 to 28 January 2026. Source tables used: Tables 43, 47, 48 and 50.

Denominator

Tables 43, 48 and 50 cover businesses that report using AI technologies. Table 47 covers all UK businesses. The two populations are displayed separately.

Uncertainty and bases

The official central estimates and supplied 95% confidence intervals are shown. Unweighted sample bases are rounded respondent counts, not counts of UK businesses. The medium and large groups generally have wider intervals because their bases are smaller.

Interpretation limits

- The findings are descriptive. They do not establish causation or business impact.
- The published package does not provide the covariance, replicate weights, raw microdata or official pairwise method needed for a fully defensible size-group significance test.
- Large businesses are a separate benchmark and are not part of the primary SME result.
- The indicators are not a required sequence and are not combined into a readiness or maturity score.
- The source does not identify vendors, implementation quality, spend, outcomes or the reasons businesses choose each pathway.

Official material

[UK Business Data Survey 2026 publication](#)

[UK Business Data Survey 2026 technical report](#)

Use this evidence as a disciplined starting point for questions and prioritisation - not as a substitute for organisation-specific assessment.